

in part by inspiring Hindus to change in order to survive in the face of negative aspects of the Muslim challenge. Christianity, too, contributed to the development of Hinduism as a new model for social action in defence of human rights, for women and for the lower castes.

But the serpent in this inter-religious Eden was the monotheistic itch to convert, which often soured Hindu relations with both Islam and Christianity. (Judaism did not, for the most part, proselytise and the Jews in any case remained a small minority in India). A more deadly sting than conversion, however, came from those Protestants within the British Raj



who, in the 19th century, tried to recast Hinduism as a monotheism, with a Bible (sometimes the Gita, sometimes the Laws of Manu, neither of which had ever before had anything remotely approaching canonical status) and a newly central, quasi-universalist ideology (often called Sanatana Dharma, or Eternal Dharma). In lifting up this monolithic form of Hinduism, the British (and the many Hindus who followed them) trampled down and largely wrote off the dominant strain of Hinduism that celebrated the multiplicity of the divine, the plurality of forms of worship. But they could not kill it; indeed, most Hindus of this type didn't even know that they were regarded as either beneath contempt or entirely non-existent. They went on worshipping their gods, singing their songs, telling their stories.

As monotheistic fundamentalism raised its ugly head in the 20th century, the constricted, sanitised form of Hinduism caught the fundamentalist virus too, and used the Western weapons of mass cultural destruction—television, the blogosphere—to broadcast its message of repression and hate. Hindus of this persuasion have attempted, as Amartya Sen eloquently expressed it, “to miniaturise the broad idea of a large India—proud of its heterodox past and its pluralist present—and to replace it by the stamp of a small India, bundled around a drastically downsized version of Hinduism”. Their hatred is directed not only against Hindus of the more diverse traditions but also, ironically, against the very monotheisms that started the rot in Hinduism: Islam and Christianity. The good news is that the other sort of Hinduism, the full screen, pluralist, creative sort, remains in the majority, and it, too, can call up mass media to rally its forces. The film industry—both in Bollywood and among the many fine inde-

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pendent filmmakers of India—has broadcast, throughout India and abroad, powerful tales of inter-religious tolerance and protests against injustice, as have individual Hindu artists and writers, jamming the mindless transmissions of the bigoted blogs.

The Hinduism of the future will have to survive in a multi-cultural, multi-religious India that simply will not be homogenised; it will have to flow with, rather than against, the currents of modernisation and globalisation. It will have to open its doors wide to welcome change, for in any case, it is too late to shut them. As India's prosperity continues to grow, so too its connections with the wider world, and its participation in global concerns for human dignity, will increasingly nourish native movements working for social reform and for the protection of individual rights, both for women and Dalits within Hinduism and for Muslims, Christians and others, whose ancestors made India their home many centuries ago. The Hinduism of the future will continue to be light years ahead of the fundamentalists of all religions in its breadth of vision, depth of spiritual understanding and spellbinding stories. ■

“
I want to see
an India where
everyone is
literate. Only
then can we
erase the
difference
between India
and Bharat.”

U.R. ANANTHAMURTHY
Noted writer in Kannada
and Jnanpith Award winner



Wendy Doniger,
who holds two
doctorates in
Sanskrit and
Indian studies,
is a professor of
the History of
Religions at the
University of
Chicago. Her
latest book is
The Hindus:
An Alternative
History.